

president elect David Morgan who had to remind the 65,000 distracted people on finals night, that Twenty20 was actually invented in England. Indeed, good sir, but who turned it into Jackpot Junction?

The sting of the IPL is being felt everywhere—in short, sharp jabs. Key members of New Zealand's first XI, including captain Daniel Vettori, were allowed to miss a warm-up match before their Test series against England began so they could play a few extra games in India.

Matthew Hayden jetted off from the IPL to turn up for Australia but broke down with injury. Yet no one complains of burn-out, too much cricket or the IPL cutting down on meaningful national duty. The majority of the international playing community, it can be safely said, has picked its side.

Everywhere else, something is stirring. There is a rumour that the English board is try-



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PAN-INDIA: Locals raise a toast to the IPL with tea, at a streetside stall near Jodhpur.

ing to set up its own Premier League, and stage its first event next year in 40 days in the August-September period where there is little or no international cricket elsewhere.

A young star from say South Africa or Pakistan could at one stage easily earn more money playing about three months of Twenty20 cricket in the Indian and prospective English league, than he would by eking out a tough, five-year career. By the sheer drawing power of its salaries and the financial imbalance in world cricket, the IPL and T20 could become the format of the future. "The game of cricket," wrote Javagal Srinath, former India pace bowler and ICC match referee, "has taken fresh guard."

It is taking guard against another version of itself; one which is a spectator-friendly, made-for-television revenue spinner. The best that

BEHIND THE SCENES

OVERHEARD AT THE IPL

► **ON THE day of the final, one** owner of a North Indian franchise was heard questioning his co-owners' understanding of cricket "What does she know of cricket?" He didn't even spare Bollywood's King Khan in his tirade; saying that from next year, SRK would have to do more than sell T-shirts to turn profits for his franchise. Because in 2009, the results on the field—which the gent said require, "better understanding of cricket"—would count.

► **THAT the Deccan Chargers** cheerleaders were, by common consensus amongst players and the IPL enterprise, the most attractive squad of all; so much so that a South African batsman's 11-month old marriage was rumoured to be on the rocks after one of those ladies caught his fancy.

► **OWNERS routinely asking** whether the start of matches could be delayed because their 'costumes' hadn't arrived or whether some could be cancelled so that the final could be brought forward in case the monsoon was early. Answer to the first, of course starts could be delayed—the final kicked off 15 minutes late as flying people and Salman Khan had to do their stuff first. Answer to the second: er... no.

► **REASON why Ambani Junior** missed out on owning a franchise: because he underestimated the

cost of doing business with the BCCI and reportedly bid only \$60m for a team, exactly half of the value Big Brother Mukesh attached to Mumbai. Now Anil A's bid for an Ahmedabad franchise is expected to come at a much higher price. Ouch.

► **THAT on the penultimate IPL** double-header weekend, a game in Bangalore overlapped into the start of another in Mohali and as the start of the second match neared, queries about which game to go with flew over Blackberries. An IPL governing council member resolved the dilemma for frantic TV producers. Switch to Mohali, he said. "Because I'm there."

► **PERFECT proof of sharing** expertise: a junior member of the Rajasthan Royals squad asking captain Shane Warne to pass on a few tips about how to compose interesting text messages.

► **TOP industrialist's tip on finals** night: that the Chennai Super Kings take fielding coaching from the Rajasthan Royals.

► **BEST in-house description** for SET Max's male anchors Kochhar, Pandit and Malhotra: the pizza delivery boys.

► **SPOTTED at a few of the IPL's** notorious parties: coke. But not the drink.

FOREIGN VS LOCAL INVESTMENTS: BATSMEN

	BATS	INNS	RUNS	AVG	100/50	S/R
Foreign	67	361	7788	26.58	6/36	133.31
Indians	96	534	9021	22.78	0/47	125.47

FOREIGN VS LOCAL INVESTMENTS: BOWLERS

	BATS	OV	RUNS	WKTS	AVG	S/R	R/O	BEST
Foreign	41	867.4	6760	251	26.93	20.74	7.79	6/14
Indians	57	1286.5	10703	353	30.32	21.87	8.31	5/17